

Process

The call arrived early on a Thursday morning. Too early. At least according to the clock. Not according to his former wife. Delhi was already fully awake. London wasn't.

Unexpected calls always landed differently when your daughter lived halfway around the world. Arjun glanced at the screen and immediately knew something was wrong. Parents developed that ability eventually. Not telepathy. Pattern recognition. Most parental emergencies announced themselves long before words arrived.

"Hey."

"Ananya is driving me insane."

Arjun smiled. The greeting was unnecessary. The subject had already been established.

"What happened?"

His former wife sighed. The sound carried exhaustion. Not anger. Not frustration. Exhaustion. The kind produced by repeating the same conversation too many times.

"She's not studying."

Arjun leaned back. "That's hardly a criminal offence."

"I'm serious."

"I know."

"No, you don't."

The response arrived immediately. The sign of someone who had been carrying the problem for weeks.

"She isn't interested. She's distracted. She's doing the minimum. I can't get through to her."

Arjun let the complaints arrive. One after another. Eventually she stopped.

The silence lingered. "You need to talk to her."

"There it is."

"There what is?"

"The handover."

His former wife laughed. "That is a surprisingly elegant way of describing abandonment."

"I prefer delegation."

"You live in another country."

"Minor detail."

"You get to be the fun parent."

"I don't think that's true."

"Arjun."

He sighed. "Fine. Occasionally true."

"Frequently true."

He laughed. "What's the situation?"

"I've spent the last three weeks fighting with science."

"Three weeks?"

"Three weeks."

"That feels excessive."

"Welcome to parenting." She paused. "Look, I'm handling maths. I'm handling social studies. I'm handling everything else." Another pause. "Science is officially your problem now."

"Officially?"

"I'm making an executive decision."

"Do I get a vote?"

"No."

"That doesn't seem democratic."

"Neither is raising a teenager."

For the first time that morning, she laughed. "Good. She's your problem now."

"She was always my problem."

"Wonderful. Hold onto that energy when she starts explaining why homework is a violation of human rights."

The video call happened two evenings later. Ananya appeared on the screen looking exactly like thirteen-year-olds had looked since the beginning of civilisation. Unimpressed by other people's priorities.

"Your mother says you and science have stopped speaking."

"I liked science before science got difficult."

"Fair."

"That's not the problem."

"Excellent."

"Why is that excellent?"

"Because now we're talking about the actual problem."

Ananya looked unconvinced. "What are you struggling with?"

"Chemical bonding."

"Okay."

"That's not a reassuring okay."

"It wasn't supposed to be."

She shared her screen. A chemistry worksheet appeared. Valencies. Atoms. Chemical bonding. School book diagrams. The usual suspects. For the next twenty minutes, Arjun explained. Or at least attempted to. The results were mixed.

"Okay," he said. "So magnesium has a valency of two."

"Why?"

"Because it wants to lose two electrons."

"Why?"

"Because that's what makes it stable."

Ananya leaned her chin on her palm, staring flatly at the camera. "Is there a specific reason the universe is this needy?"

Arjun sighed. "Because if it doesn't, it doesn't get its full outer shell. It's just how chemistry works, Ananya."

"I'm serious," Ananya insisted.

"I know." Ten minutes later he tried a diagram. That went worse. "Are you understanding this?"

"No."

"Any of it?"

"Less than before."

"That feels unlikely."

"It also happens to be true."

Another attempt. This time with cue cards. Five minutes later:

"This is somehow more confusing."

Arjun leaned back. Ananya folded her arms. Both stared at the screen. Neither looked particularly victorious.

Finally, Ananya sighed. "I still don't get it."

"Me neither."

She looked up. "What?"

"I don't understand why my explanation isn't working."

Ananya smiled despite herself. "That sounds like a you problem."

"That feels unfair."

"It feels accurate."

Silence.

"Want to try again tomorrow?" Arjun suggested.

Ananya groaned. "This feels suspiciously like homework."

"That's because it is."

"Good. Honesty."

Arjun laughed. "It's Saturday. Let's stop before we both start disliking chemistry more than necessary."

"Reasonable."

"We'll try again tomorrow morning."

"Do I have a choice?"

"Not really."

"Good. Consistency."

The call ended. No breakthrough. No success. No chemical bonding. Just two people agreeing to try again.

The next day, Arjun sent a message first thing in the morning.

Arjun: Ready for round two?

No response. Ten minutes later:

Ananya: I literally just woke up.

Arjun: It's almost lunchtime.

Ananya: That's a judgement.

Arjun: That's a fact.

Several minutes passed.

Ananya: Not in the mood.

Arjun: Encouraging update.

Ananya: Going to Anika's first.

Arjun: Science revision with Anika?

Ananya: Absolutely not.

Arjun: 4 p.m.?

A pause.

Ananya: Fine. But only because now I'm curious whether you're going to fail again.

At 4:07 p.m., she appeared. Still sceptical. Still unconvinced. Still not understanding chemical bonding.

“Ready?”

“No.”

“Good enough.”

The first twenty minutes looked suspiciously similar to the previous day. Progress. Confusion. Small breakthroughs. Immediate collapses. Then something changed.

“Wait.”

“What?”

“Me and Anika found a TikTok.”

Arjun closed his eyes. “Nothing good has ever started with that sentence.”

“It has a song.”

“That’s significantly worse.”

“It works.” She grinned, then started singing a ridiculous melody. Valencies turned into lyrics. Chemistry turned into rhythm. ♪ *Magnesium, Mercury, Carbon, Oxygen* ♪. Numbers attached themselves to music.

Arjun stared. “What?”

“It works.”

It did. The valencies were suddenly available. Not understood. But available. Which turned out to be enough. Because the valencies had never really been the problem. They were the missing piece beneath the problem.

Arjun leaned back. “Aha.”

“What?”

“I’ve been trying to teach chemical bonding.”

“That was the plan.”

“Wrong plan.”

Ananya frowned. “That seems concerning.”

“Yesterday I kept explaining chemistry.”

“And?”

“And you were still trying to remember basic valencies.”

She looked at him. “So?”

“So every explanation depended on information you didn't actually have access to yet.”

A pause.

“Oh.”

“Exactly.”

Ananya raised an eyebrow. “You spent an hour building the second floor without checking whether the ground floor existed.”

“That feels unfairly accurate.”

“Thank you.”

“You don't get points for insulting the teacher.”

“I absolutely do.”

For a second she looked pleased with herself. Then immediately tried to hide it.

Arjun smiled. “Excellent.”

“What's excellent?”

“You just diagnosed the problem better than I did.”

Ananya rolled her eyes. “Don't make this a life lesson.”

“Wouldn't dream of it.” He pointed back to the worksheet. “Now let's try a bonding question.”

They worked through one. Not perfect. But better. Then another. Better again. Then a third. The confusion began receding. Slowly. Not dramatically. Like fog.

Eventually Arjun gave her a small test. Five questions. Ananya completed it. Two wrong. Three right. She looked disappointed. Arjun looked delighted.

“Why are you smiling?”

“Because yesterday was zero.”

“That's an annoyingly low standard.”

“It's an excellent standard.”

They reviewed the mistakes. Tried again. Five new questions. This time she got four right. For several seconds Ananya stared at the page. Then smiled. Not at him. At the questions. At the fact that they now made sense.

“Wait.”

“What?”

“I think I actually get this.”

Arjun watched her eyes trace the lines on the screen. “Don’t say it out loud,” he murmured. “You’ll scare it away.”

She laughed, but her eyes never left the worksheet. Then she completed another question. Correctly. This time Arjun said nothing. He simply watched. The satisfaction arrived unexpectedly. Not because she got the answer right. Not because he had explained it well. Not because science suddenly mattered. Because they had found a way through.

The answer wasn't the interesting part. The route had been. An hour later, his phone buzzed.

Ananya: Did two more.

Ananya: Both right.

Ananya: Don't get smug.

Arjun smiled. Too late.

Investigation Journal

Why did finding another way feel better than getting the answer right?

